Pre-mortem

Imagine the work has already failed, explain why, then act now to prevent the most likely causes.

Run a Project · Inspired by Gary Klein's Pre-mortem · Prospective Hindsight · Risks Before They Happen

LEGEND

Pink Sticky = Why it failed

Dot = Vote (3 per person)

1 The Scenario

READ IT ALOUD · SPEAK AS IF IT HAS ALREADY HAPPENED

It's _____ *and this has failed badly. What went wrong?*

Project, plan or release: _____ Failure looks like: _____

2 Why It Failed

SILENT WRITING FIRST · ONE REASON PER STICKY

- Everyone writes alone for 5 minutes, in the past tense: “We lost our key supplier”
- Think wide: people, tech, customers, money, dependencies, decisions

Pink stickies, clustered by theme

3 Top Risks

AFTER DOT VOTING

#	REASON	LIKELY	IMPACT	VOTES

4 Prevent or Detect

FOR EACH TOP RISK

TOP RISK	WE'LL PREVENT IT BY…	EARLY WARNING SIGN	OWNER

5 Next Steps

- [ ] Top risks added to the RAID Log
- [ ] Prevention actions added to the backlog
- [ ] Warning signs visible on the team board
- [ ] Plan or scope changed where needed
- [ ] Re-run before the next big milestone

Review these risks on: _____

“It's six months from now and this has failed. What happened?”

“Which of these are we quietly hoping won't happen?”

© 2026 Eric Parker · CC BY 4.0 · eparker71.github.io/agile-ways-of-working